RAJALAKSHMI ENGINEERING COLLEGE

(Autonomous)

B.E. CSE – CYBER SECURITY

CR23532 – CYBER AND DIGITAL FORENSICS

CASE STUDY ASSIGNMENT

ASSIGNMENT – 2

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Case Study Submission

1. Suspected Unauthorized Access to a College Server

1. Case Study Overview

This mini-project presents a structured digital forensic investigation of suspected unauthorized access to a college departmental server. The administrator has reported that confidential examination-related files were accessed and copied outside normal working hours. The available evidence consists of an administrator's complaint, a suspect workstation, server access logs, a USB storage device recovered from the workstation, and selected files that may be relevant to the incident.

The objective is not merely to identify a suspicious user or device, but to reconstruct the incident in a scientifically defensible manner. The investigation must preserve the original evidence, document every action, establish the reliability of extracted information, correlate evidence from independent sources, and present conclusions with an appropriate level of confidence.

1.1 Investigation Objectives

- Determine whether unauthorized access to the departmental server occurred.
- Identify the accounts, devices, files, and time periods associated with the suspected activity.
- Determine whether files were copied to removable media or another destination.
- Preserve digital evidence without altering the original sources.
- Construct a reliable event timeline by correlating server, workstation, USB, and file-system evidence.
- Produce a clear forensic report suitable for review by college management or an authorized disciplinary/investigative authority.

1.2 Scope and Assumptions

- The investigation is limited to the evidence sources identified in the case background.
- Investigators have appropriate institutional authorization to acquire and examine the devices and records.
- System clocks may not be perfectly synchronized; therefore, time-zone and clock-offset checks are required.
- The USB device is treated as potential evidence, not automatically as proof of wrongdoing.
- No conclusion about a particular individual should be made solely from the presence of a device or user account; evidence must be corroborated.

1.3 Evidence Handling Principle

The central forensic principle is to preserve the original state of evidence and perform examination on verified forensic copies wherever possible. Each acquisition should be documented with identifiers, timestamps, personnel details, acquisition method, and cryptographic hash values. Hash verification provides a mechanism to demonstrate that the forensic image examined corresponds to the acquired evidence.

1.4 Investigation Questions

1. What account or device accessed the server outside normal working hours?
2. Which files were accessed, modified, opened, or transferred?
3. Was removable media connected to the suspect workstation during the relevant period?
4. Do workstation artifacts corroborate the server log activity?
5. Can a consistent sequence of events be established from independent evidence sources?

2. Identification, Collection, Examination, Analysis and Presentation

2.1 Identification

The identification phase begins with the administrator's complaint and an initial incident assessment. Investigators should define the incident window, affected server or department, suspected file categories, known users, and potential evidence locations. Volatile information such as active sessions, logged-in users, running processes and network connections may be relevant if a live system is encountered. The team should also identify the suspect workstation, server logs, USB device and relevant files.

- Record the complaint and incident reference number.
- Identify systems, accounts, storage media and logs potentially connected to the incident.
- Establish the approximate date/time window and relevant time zone.
- Record who had legitimate access during the relevant period.

2.2 Collection

Collection should be performed under documented authority and according to institutional forensic procedures. Where feasible, a forensic image of storage media should be created rather than conducting extensive examination directly on the original. Write blockers should be used when appropriate for storage devices. Server logs should be preserved in their original form and copied for analysis. The USB device should be imaged separately, with its unique identifier and condition documented.

- Assign evidence IDs and maintain a chain-of-custody record.
- Photograph/document device condition, labels, ports and connections where appropriate.
- Acquire forensic images using validated procedures.
- Calculate and record cryptographic hashes of acquired evidence.
- Store originals and working copies securely.

2.3 Examination

Examination involves extracting relevant artifacts from verified copies. The workstation may be examined for user activity, file-system metadata, browser or application artifacts where relevant, USB connection history, recent files, event logs and other system records. Server logs should be parsed for authentication, file access, session and transfer events. The USB image should be examined for file-system contents, timestamps and relevant metadata.

- Verify the hash of each working copy before examination.
- Extract artifacts systematically and record source locations.
- Preserve original timestamps and metadata during extraction.
- Use validated forensic software and document tool versions/settings.

2.4 Analysis

Analysis converts extracted artifacts into an explanation of what happened. Investigators should correlate server authentication records with workstation activity and USB connection events. A single artifact should not be treated as conclusive when alternative explanations exist. For example, a username in a log may show that an account was used, but additional evidence is required before attributing the activity to a particular person.

- Correlate timestamps after checking clock offsets and time zones.
- Compare login events with file-access and removable-media activity.
- Identify inconsistencies and investigate alternative explanations.
- Distinguish observed facts from interpretations and conclusions.

2.5 Presentation

The presentation phase communicates findings in a form that another person can understand and independently assess. The final report should identify the scope, evidence examined, methodology, findings, limitations and conclusion. Technical details should be retained in appendices or supporting exhibits, while management-facing conclusions should use plain language and clearly explain the significance of the evidence.

- Present a concise executive summary.
- Use evidence IDs and exhibit references consistently.
- Show the event timeline and key correlations.
- State limitations and confidence appropriately.
- Separate facts, analysis and conclusions.

3. Forensic Investigation Flowchart

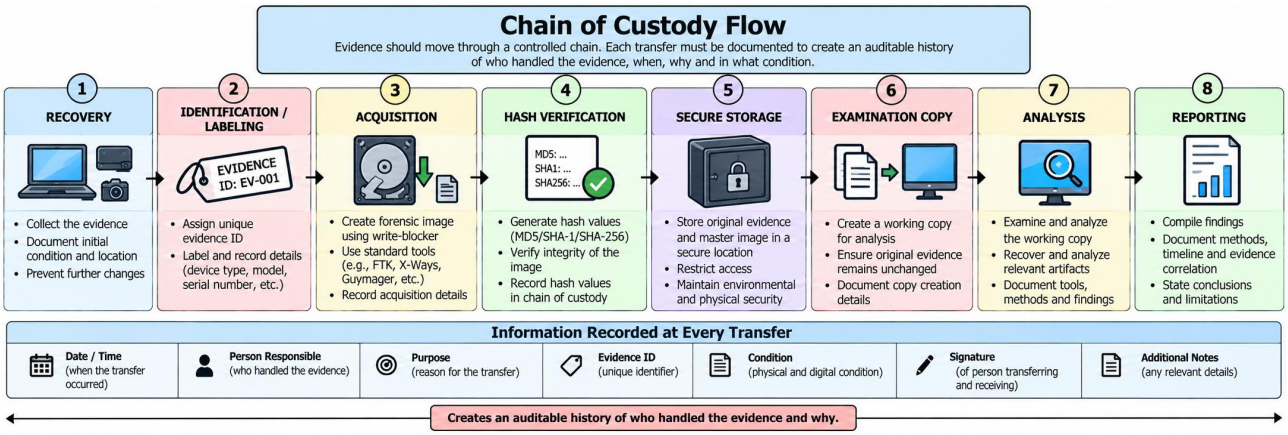
The following flow represents the proposed sequence for this case. It is designed to minimize evidence contamination and maintain traceability from the initial complaint through final reporting.

Step	Activity	Purpose
1	Administrator Complaint	Incident reported and initial facts recorded.
2	Preserve Scene & Authority	Confirm authorization; prevent alteration or deletion of relevant evidence.
3	Identify Evidence	Server, workstation, USB device, logs, files and supporting records.
4	Document & Acquire	Record condition; create forensic images/copies using appropriate controls.
5	Hash & Seal	Calculate hashes, label evidence and maintain chain of custody.
6	Examine Copies	Extract logs, file metadata, user activity and USB artifacts.
7	Build Timeline	Normalize timestamps and correlate independent evidence.
8	Analyze & Corroborate	Test hypotheses, identify inconsistencies and alternative explanations.
9	Conclude	State supported findings, limitations and confidence.
10	Report & Present	Prepare report, exhibits, timeline and management briefing.

3.1 Decision Points

- If a live system is still running, the team must decide whether volatile evidence should be captured before shutdown, based on authorization and risk of evidence loss.
- If a storage device cannot be imaged safely, investigators should document the limitation and use an appropriate alternative acquisition procedure.
- If timestamps conflict across systems, investigators should investigate clock synchronization and record any identified offset before building the final timeline.
- If evidence does not sufficiently establish attribution, the report should state that limitation instead of overstating the conclusion.

3.2 Chain of Custody Flow



4. Potential Digital Evidence and Investigative Value

The evidence below is classified according to its potential contribution to establishing the occurrence, method, timing and attribution of the incident. Classification is based on investigative value and does not imply that an item by itself proves the allegation.

Evidence ID	Evidence Item	Potential Artifacts	Investigative Value	Preservation Priority
E-01	Administrator complaint	Incident time window, affected files, reported circumstances	High – establishes initial allegation and scope	High
E-02	Departmental server logs	Authentication, session, file-access, transfer/network events	Very High – may establish when/how server resources were accessed	Very High
E-03	Suspect workstation	Event logs, user activity, file metadata, recent files, USB artifacts	Very High – may corroborate access and local activity	Very High
E-04	Recovered USB device	File-system contents, metadata, connection/usage context	High – may indicate possible file transfer or storage	Very High
E-05	Relevant examination files	Metadata, access/modify times, contents, hashes	High – identifies affected information and possible changes	High
E-06	User/account records	Account ownership, permissions, login history	Medium/High – assists attribution and access analysis	High
E-07	System time configuration	Time zone, clock configuration, synchronization records	Medium – essential for accurate timeline correlation	Medium

4.1 Evidence Classification

- Direct evidence: An artifact that directly records an event, such as a server log entry showing a successful authentication at a specific time.
- Circumstantial evidence: Evidence that supports an inference when combined with other artifacts, such as a USB connection event occurring shortly before a file was accessed.
- Corroborative evidence: An independent artifact that strengthens another finding, such as matching server access time with workstation activity.
- Exculpatory or alternative evidence: Evidence that may indicate that the suspected user or device was not responsible, or that another explanation is possible. Investigators must actively consider such evidence.

4.2 Recommended Evidence Record

Each item should receive a unique evidence identifier. The evidence record should include description, serial number or unique identifier where available, source/location, date/time acquired, acquisition method, hash algorithm and value, person collecting it, storage location, and every subsequent transfer. This record becomes part of the case documentation.

5. Establishing the Incident Timeline

A timeline is one of the most useful analytical products in this case because the incident concerns activity outside normal working hours. Investigators should not rely on one timestamp. Instead, events from server logs, workstation artifacts, USB evidence and relevant file metadata should be normalized and correlated.

5.1 Timeline Construction Procedure

1. Define the investigation window using the complaint and known business/college hours.
2. Record the time zone and clock configuration for each relevant system.
3. Check for evidence of clock drift or synchronization problems.
4. Extract timestamps from authentication, session, file-access and transfer records.
5. Extract workstation event times and removable-media connection events.
6. Examine USB file-system metadata and relevant file timestamps.
7. Convert timestamps to a common reporting standard while retaining the original time where necessary.
8. Sort events chronologically and group events that are closely related.
9. Compare independent sources and identify corroborating or conflicting evidence.
10. Mark uncertain timestamps and explain the reason for uncertainty in the report.

5.2 Illustrative Timeline Format

Time	Source	Observed Event	Interpretation	Confidence
19:42	Server log	Successful authentication using an authorized account	Account was used to access the server	To be assessed
19:45	Server log	Examination-related file accessed	Requested file was accessed	To be assessed
19:47	Workstation	User/session activity recorded	Potential corroboration of local activity	To be assessed
19:49	USB artifact	Removable device connection recorded	Potential transfer opportunity	To be assessed
19:52	File system	Relevant file timestamp observed on USB image	Possible transfer/storage relationship	To be assessed
20:03	Server log	Session ended / logout recorded	End of observed server session	To be assessed

Note: The above timeline is an illustrative format only. The times and events are hypothetical and must not be presented as actual findings from this case.

5.3 Suitable Forensic Tools and Their Intended Use

Tool / Category	Intended Forensic Procedure
FTK Imager / equivalent acquisition tool	Create and verify forensic images; calculate hashes; preserve original evidence.
Autopsy / The Sleuth Kit	Examine file systems, metadata, deleted artifacts and timelines from forensic copies.
Plaso / log2timeline	Aggregate timestamped artifacts into a normalized forensic timeline.
Wireshark (if network capture exists)	Analyze packet captures for relevant communications or transfers; only where such captures are lawfully available.
Hashing utilities (SHA-256)	Verify integrity of acquired evidence and exported artifacts.

6. Precautions for Collection and Preservation

Digital evidence is fragile because ordinary system operations can modify timestamps, logs, temporary files and other artifacts. The investigation must therefore prioritize preservation before extensive examination.

Precaution	Purpose
Authorization and scope	Confirm written authority and define the systems, accounts, dates and evidence categories within scope.
Documentation before handling	Record device condition, labels, connections, serial numbers and relevant environmental details before collection.
Avoid unnecessary interaction	Do not browse, open files or execute programs on the original evidence unless the approved procedure requires it.
Write protection	Use hardware/software write protection where appropriate during acquisition of storage media.
Forensic imaging	Create a bit-for-bit or otherwise appropriate forensic acquisition using a validated process.
Cryptographic hashing	Generate SHA-256 or another approved cryptographic hash and retain the value in the evidence record.
Secure storage	Keep original evidence in controlled storage with access limited to authorized personnel.
Working copies	Perform examination and analysis on verified copies rather than the original whenever feasible.
Chain of custody	Record every transfer, person, date/time, purpose and evidence condition.
Tool and method documentation	Record forensic software names, versions, acquisition settings and significant commands/procedures.

7. Final Forensic Report Structure

Report Section	Expected Content
1. Cover Page	Case title, case/reference number, investigator, institution, date and confidentiality marking.
2. Executive Summary	A short, non-technical description of the allegation, key findings and conclusion.
3. Case Background	Complaint, incident scope, known facts and investigation objectives.
4. Authority and Scope	Authorization, systems examined, dates covered and limitations.
5. Evidence Inventory	Evidence IDs, descriptions, acquisition details and hash values.
6. Methodology	Collection, preservation, examination and analysis procedures.
7. Findings	Objective observations supported by evidence references and exhibits.

Report Section	Expected Content
8. Timeline	Chronological reconstruction with source references and time-zone assumptions.
9. Analysis	Correlation of evidence, alternative explanations and reasoning.
10. Conclusion	Supported conclusion stated without exaggeration or unsupported attribution.
11. Limitations	Missing logs, uncertain timestamps, inaccessible systems, incomplete evidence, or other constraints.
12. Appendices	Hash list, chain-of-custody records, screenshots, extracted artifacts and detailed tables.

8. Legal and Ethical Considerations

A college environment does not remove the need for authorization, privacy protection and evidence-handling discipline. Investigators should operate within applicable institutional policies and Indian law, and should collect only evidence that is relevant and authorized for the investigation.

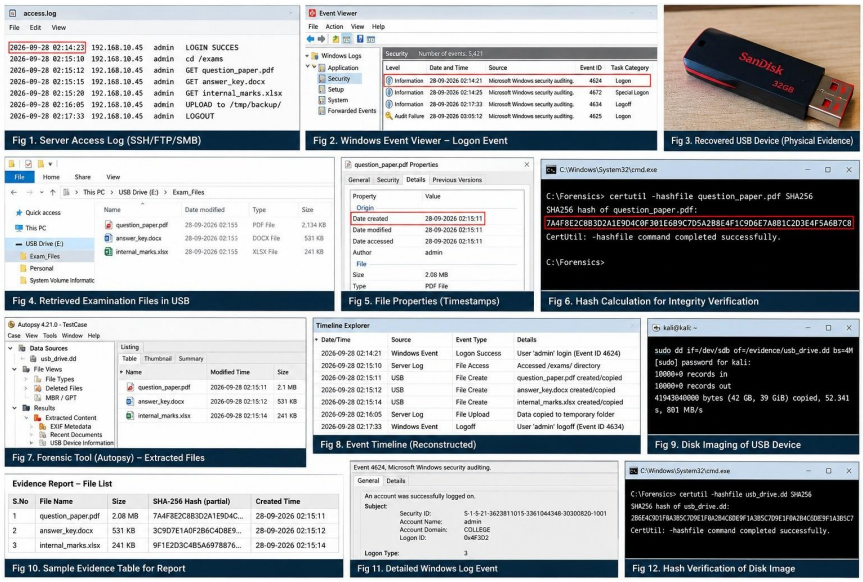
- Obtain appropriate institutional authorization before acquiring or examining a student's or employee's device, account or data.
- Follow applicable provisions of Indian law and institutional rules governing electronic records, privacy, unauthorized access and admissibility. Where a matter may become disciplinary or legal, the institution should involve its authorized legal/administrative personnel.
- Use the minimum necessary scope of collection. Avoid unrelated personal information where it is not relevant to the investigation.
- Maintain confidentiality because examination-related files and user data may contain sensitive information.
- Preserve original evidence and maintain a documented chain of custody so that the integrity and provenance of evidence can be explained.
- Do not alter, fabricate, delete or selectively omit relevant evidence. Investigators should record both inculpatory and exculpatory observations.
- Use forensic tools and procedures responsibly. A tool output is an artifact to be interpreted, not automatically a final conclusion.
- Ensure that any monitoring, account access or network collection performed during the investigation is authorized and proportionate.

9. Presentation to a Non-Technical Authority

A principal, dean, examination officer or disciplinary committee may not need the technical details of file-system structures or forensic software. The investigator should therefore present the findings in a layered manner.

1. Begin with the question: what happened, when did it happen, and what evidence supports that conclusion?
2. Use a one-page executive summary with the incident window, affected resources and major findings.
3. Present a simple timeline showing the most important correlated events.
4. Use evidence IDs rather than technical jargon wherever possible.
5. Explain technical terms briefly; for example, describe a cryptographic hash as a digital integrity value used to show that an acquired copy has not changed.
6. Distinguish confirmed observations from interpretations and from conclusions.
7. State uncertainty openly. If the evidence shows that an account was used but does not identify the person physically operating the device, the report should say so.

8. Keep detailed logs, screenshots, hash values and forensic procedures in appendices.



10. Sample Executive Conclusion

Based on the proposed forensic methodology, the investigation should determine whether the server records demonstrate access to confidential examination-related files outside normal working hours and whether that activity is corroborated by workstation and removable-media artifacts. A conclusion should be issued only after verifying the integrity of the acquired evidence and correlating independent sources. If the evidence demonstrates a consistent sequence of account use, file access and removable-media activity, the report may conclude that the evidence supports the occurrence of unauthorized access and possible copying. However, attribution to a particular individual should be made only when sufficient independent evidence establishes that connection.

2. Linking a Suspicious File to a User Using File-System Evidence

1. Case Study Overview

This case study concerns a shared desktop computer used by several staff members. Investigators have discovered a suspicious executable, hidden files, encrypted documents, browser-related artifacts and multiple user accounts. The principal investigative question is whether file-system evidence can reliably associate the creation or access of the suspicious files with one particular user account.

The investigation should follow a forensic methodology in which the original evidence is preserved, a verified forensic copy is examined, and conclusions are based on correlations among multiple independent artifacts. The presence of a file under a user directory may be relevant, but it should not automatically be treated as proof that the account holder personally created or executed the file.

1.1 Investigation Objectives

- Document the hardware and software environment before forensic examination.
- Identify the relevant storage devices, operating systems and file systems.
- Locate suspicious, hidden and encrypted files and record their metadata.
- Correlate file-system artifacts with user accounts, login activity and application/browser artifacts.
- Use ILookIX or an equivalent forensic examination workflow to organize and analyze the evidence.
- Distinguish direct user-attribution evidence from contextual or supporting evidence.
- Document alternative explanations and limitations before reaching a conclusion.

1.2 Scope and Assumptions

- The computer is assumed to have multiple legitimate users and multiple local or domain accounts.
- The suspicious executable is treated as an investigative lead, not automatically as malware or proof of misconduct.
- Investigators have appropriate authorization to acquire and examine the computer and associated data.
- Any ILookIX interface or feature used should be verified against the installed version; this assignment describes the intended forensic workflow rather than claiming that a particular screen was actually used.
- All example timestamps, file names and findings in this report are illustrative unless supported by actual evidence.

1.3 Key Investigative Question

Can the available evidence establish a reliable relationship between the suspicious file and a particular user account, while ruling out reasonable alternative explanations such as shared credentials, automated processes, malware activity, copied profiles or another person using the workstation?

2. Hardware and Software Components to Document

Before analysis begins, investigators should create a system inventory. Documentation provides context for interpreting file-system artifacts and creates a record of the original environment.

Category	Items to Document	Forensic Relevance
Computer	Manufacturer, model, asset ID, serial number, physical condition	Identifies the evidence source and supports chain of custody.
Storage	HDD/SSD/NVMe, capacity, serial number, partitions, encryption	Determines acquisition and file-system examination requirements.

Category	Items to Document	Forensic Relevance
Removable media	USB devices, external disks, memory cards, labels/serials	May contain copies of suspicious files or related artifacts.
Firmware/boot	BIOS/UEFI settings and boot configuration where relevant	May explain alternate boot environments or system changes.
Operating system	Windows/Linux version, build, architecture, installed updates	Provides context for event logs and file-system behavior.
File systems	NTFS, FAT/exFAT, ext4 or other relevant file systems	Determines available metadata and forensic artifacts.
User accounts	Account names, SIDs/UIDs, privileges, profile paths	Supports correlation between files and users.
Applications	Browsers, office software, archive/encryption tools and security software	May generate artifacts related to file access or downloads.
Network	Hostname, IP configuration, mapped drives, network shares	May identify external sources or shared storage.
Security controls	Antivirus/EDR, firewall, encryption and logging configuration	May provide additional evidence or explain missing artifacts.

2.1 Pre-Analysis Documentation

- Assign a unique evidence ID to the computer and each storage device.
- Photograph or document labels, ports, connections and visible condition where appropriate.
- Record the date, time, investigator and authorization reference.
- Record system power state and note whether volatile information may need preservation.
- Do not open files or change system settings on the original evidence unless the approved procedure specifically requires it.
- Record the acquisition method, forensic tool/version and cryptographic hash values.

2.2 Why the Hardware/Software Inventory Matters

A suspicious file has meaning only in context. An executable in a user's profile may have been downloaded through a browser, extracted from an archive, installed by software deployment, or placed by another process. Knowing the operating system, installed applications, storage layout and user profiles helps investigators interpret the artifact rather than drawing conclusions from its file name alone.

3. Storage Devices, Operating Systems, File Systems and Metadata

3.1 Storage Devices

Storage devices preserve the data from which forensic artifacts are extracted. A forensic acquisition should capture relevant partitions and unallocated space where appropriate. Investigators should preserve the original device and work from a verified forensic image whenever feasible. The acquisition record should include device identity, capacity, partition structure, acquisition method and hash values.

3.2 Operating Systems

Operating systems maintain user profiles, security logs, application records, temporary data and configuration information. On a Windows workstation, examples may include user profile directories, Windows event logs, registry artifacts and application-specific records. On Linux systems, relevant sources can include authentication logs, shell history, user directories and file metadata. The exact artifacts depend on the operating system and version.

3.3 File Systems

A file system provides the structure used to store and reference files. File-system analysis can reveal paths, allocation status, timestamps, ownership information and other metadata. NTFS, FAT/exFAT and Linux file systems each provide different metadata structures and forensic artifacts.

3.4 Metadata

- File name and full path can show where the artifact was stored.
- Creation, modification and access timestamps can assist in timeline construction, subject to operating-system semantics and possible manipulation.
- File size and extension can support identification of content type.
- Ownership or security identifiers can help connect a file to a user or security principal.
- Hash values can identify identical files and support integrity verification.
- Application metadata may reveal downloads, document authorship or recent activity, but should be interpreted cautiously.

3.5 Metadata Caution

Metadata is valuable but not infallible. Timestamps may change when files are copied, extracted, synchronized or restored. User identifiers can be shared or misused. File names and extensions can be deliberately changed. Investigators should therefore correlate metadata with independent evidence such as login events, application activity, browser history and execution artifacts.

4. Hidden and Encrypted Files

4.1 Hidden Files

Hidden files are files or directories configured so that ordinary file-browsing interfaces do not display them by default. Hiding an item does not necessarily make it forensically invisible. A forensic examination can inspect directory structures, file-system metadata and other artifacts to identify hidden entries.

- Record the full path, attributes and timestamps of hidden files.
- Determine whether the hidden attribute is normal for the operating system or unusual for the context.
- Examine surrounding files and directories for relationships.
- Do not modify file attributes on the original evidence merely to make files visible.
- Document how the hidden artifact was identified and extracted.

4.2 Encrypted Files

Encryption can prevent investigators from directly reading the contents of a file even when the file itself is identified. Investigators should preserve the encrypted artifact in its original state and document its location, size, timestamps and associated metadata. Authorized recovery methods, available keys, passwords or lawful access mechanisms may be considered where permitted.

- Do not attempt uncontrolled password guessing or alteration of the encrypted source.
- Preserve the original encrypted file and work with a forensic copy.
- Record the encryption/container type when it can be identified.
- Look for supporting artifacts such as application records, filenames, recent-file references and access timestamps.
- Clearly distinguish the existence of an encrypted file from proof of its contents.

4.3 Forensic Significance

Hidden and encrypted artifacts can be important leads, but neither characteristic alone establishes malicious intent or user attribution. A legitimate application may create hidden files, and encryption may be used for ordinary privacy or organizational security. The investigator must examine context and corroborating evidence.

5. Evidence-Linkage Matrix

The following matrix demonstrates how different artifact types may be correlated. It is an analytical model rather than a statement that these artifacts were actually found in the case.

Evidence / Artifact	Example Observation	Possible User Link	Strength	Corroboration Required
Suspicious executable	C:\Users\UserA\Downloads\update.exe	Located within UserA profile	Medium	Browser/download record, login activity, execution artifact
File creation timestamp	Created at 21:14	Activity occurred during a UserA session	Medium	Session/login records and system clock validation
Security log	UserA successful logon at 21:05	UserA account was active	Medium	Workstation activity and other account evidence
Execution artifact	Executable launched from UserA profile	Supports execution by a process/session associated with UserA	High	Process/application logs and timeline correlation
Browser history	Download of update.exe at 21:10	May link file acquisition to UserA browser session	High	Download record, cache and account/session evidence
Recent files artifact	Suspicious file appears in recent activity	Shows application interaction with the file	Medium	Application logs and user session
File ownership/permissions	Security descriptor includes UserA	Shows account association with file permissions	Low/Medium	Login and activity artifacts
USB artifact	USB device connected during relevant interval	Provides possible transfer opportunity	Medium	USB connection history and destination file metadata
Encrypted document	Stored in UserA Documents	Shows storage under user profile	Low/Medium	Application access records and session evidence
Browser profile artifact	User-specific browser profile active	May associate acquisition activity with profile	High if independently verified	Account ownership and login evidence

5.1 Direct vs Supporting Evidence

Artifact Type	Example	Interpretation
Direct attribution evidence	Verified execution/access event tied to a specific authenticated session and corroborated independently	Can strongly connect a user account/session to an activity.
Supporting/contextual evidence	File located in a user's folder or matching timestamp	Supports a hypothesis but may have innocent or alternative explanations.
Neutral evidence	File type, common OS artifact or generic system record	Provides technical context but little attribution value.

6. ILookIX Forensic Analysis Workflow

ILookIX can be treated in this assignment as the forensic examination platform used to organize acquired evidence and analyze artifacts. The exact menus and supported formats may vary by installed version. The investigator should therefore document the version used and follow the approved laboratory procedure.

6.1 Step-by-Step Workflow

1. Case creation

Create a new case and record the case identifier, investigator, incident description and scope.

2. Evidence preparation

Identify the forensic image or other authorized evidence source. Verify the acquisition hash before examination.

3. Evidence import/acquisition

Import the forensic evidence into the case according to the ILookIX workflow supported by the installed version. Preserve the original acquisition separately.

4. Evidence indexing

Allow the platform to process/index supported file-system and artifact data. Record any unsupported or failed items.

5. File-system examination

Browse partitions, directories and file records. Search for the suspicious executable, hidden files and encrypted documents.

6. Metadata examination

Review paths, timestamps, file sizes, ownership/permissions and other available metadata.

7. User/artifact correlation

Examine user profiles, account-related artifacts and relevant operating-system/application records.

8. Browser analysis

Where supported, review browser history, downloads, cached artifacts and relevant user-profile data.

9. Timeline analysis

Use available timeline/event features or export relevant timestamps and correlate them with other evidence.

10. Evidence tagging/reporting

Tag relevant artifacts, preserve references to their source locations and generate an examination report or export.

11. Independent verification

Re-check important findings against the original forensic image or another validated tool/process where appropriate.

6.2 Expected Evidence Obtained

- Directory and file listings for suspicious artifacts.
- File-system metadata and timestamps.
- User profile paths and account identifiers.

- Relevant operating-system event artifacts.
- Browser/download artifacts where available.
- Hidden-file and encrypted-file indicators.
- Timeline entries connecting events from multiple sources.
- Hashes and evidence references for important files.
- An examination report identifying the source of each finding.

6.3 Interpretation Rule

ILookIX output should be treated as forensic evidence requiring interpretation. An automatically generated artifact or timeline entry should not be presented as proof of user intent. Investigators should validate important findings, document the source artifact and explain how the finding contributes to the overall hypothesis.

7. Limitations and Alternative Explanations

Before attributing the suspicious activity to a particular user, investigators must consider explanations that could produce the same artifacts.

Limitation / Alternative	Effect on Attribution
Shared credentials	A user account may have been used by another person. A username does not necessarily establish physical identity.
Remote access	Another device or remote session may have accessed the workstation or shared resources using valid credentials.
Automated processes	Scheduled tasks, software updates, synchronization tools or security software may create or modify files without direct user action.
Malware activity	Malicious software could create files, execute programs or alter metadata while the legitimate user account is active.
Copied or restored data	Files may have been copied from another system, restored from backup or synchronized from cloud/network storage.
Timestamp limitations	Clock drift, time-zone differences, copying and extraction can affect timestamp interpretation.
Metadata manipulation	An attacker or application may deliberately alter file names, timestamps or other metadata.
Incomplete evidence	Deleted files, missing logs, unavailable browser data or damaged media may prevent a complete reconstruction.

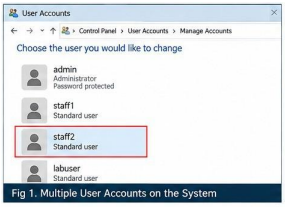
7.1 How to Reduce Attribution Risk

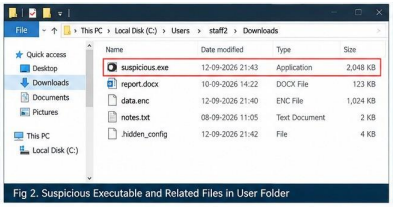
- Use multiple independent evidence sources rather than relying on one artifact.
- Establish that the relevant account was actually active during the event window.
- Correlate file activity with execution, browser, authentication and removable-media artifacts where available.
- Check whether the system was accessible remotely or shared by multiple users.
- Investigate both supporting and contradictory evidence.
- State the level of confidence and limitations in the final report.

8. Sample Findings and Reporting Structure

Because the case background does not provide actual forensic images or extracted artifacts, this section provides a model for how findings should be reported after examination. It should not be presented as an actual forensic result.

Finding ID	Finding Format	Evidence Reference	Interpretation
F-01	Suspicious executable identified at a specific path	File-system record	Artifact exists at the documented location.
F-02	File metadata falls within the incident window	Metadata record	Artifact timing is relevant but requires correlation.
F-03	User account was authenticated during the relevant interval	Security artifact	Account was active; attribution requires further corroboration.
F-04	Browser/download artifact corresponds to suspicious file	Browser artifact	May connect acquisition to the user session.
F-05	Execution/access artifact corresponds to the same session	Execution artifact	Stronger attribution when independently corroborated.


Fig 1. Multiple User Accounts on the System


Fig 2. Suspicious Executable and Related Files in User Folder

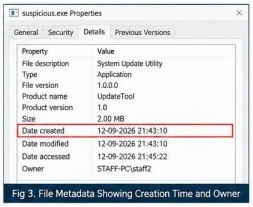
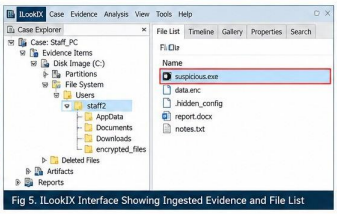

Fig 3. File Metadata Showing Creation Time and Owner


Fig 4. Hidden Files and Encrypted File in User Directory


Fig 5. ILookIX Interface Showing Ingested Evidence and File List

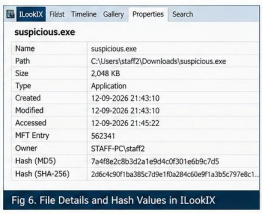

Fig 6. File Details and Hash Values in ILookIX


Fig 7. File System Timeline Showing User Activity

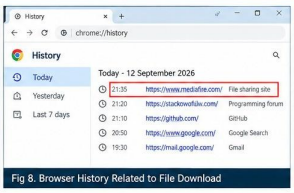

Fig 8. Browser History Related to File Download


Fig 9. Command Prompt Showing Hidden Files

9. Conclusion

File-system evidence can provide a strong foundation for linking a suspicious artifact to a user account, but attribution should be based on correlation rather than a single file path or timestamp. The combination of storage-device information, operating-system artifacts, file-system metadata, user profiles, browser records and execution-related evidence can establish a coherent sequence of events.

A suitable ILookIX workflow begins with documented evidence acquisition and integrity verification, followed by controlled import, indexing, file-system examination, metadata analysis, user/artifact correlation and timeline reconstruction. Important findings should be tagged and reported with their original evidence references. Where the evidence does not establish who physically performed an action, the report should clearly state that limitation.

9.1 Conclusion for Authority

The forensic examination should determine whether the suspicious file is consistently associated with a particular authenticated user session and whether independent artifacts corroborate acquisition, creation or execution activity. If multiple independent artifacts align within a validated time window, the evidence may support a strong association between the user account and the activity. However, a conclusion that the individual personally performed the activity should only be made when the evidence addresses reasonable alternatives such as shared credentials, remote access, automation or malware.

3. Forensic Imaging and Safekeeping of a Suspect Storage Device

1. Case Study Overview

This case study addresses the forensic acquisition and safekeeping of a laptop and an attached USB storage device seized during an investigation into suspected data theft. Because digital storage is easily altered by ordinary system operations, investigators must preserve the original media, document its condition, acquire a verified forensic image and conduct examination on a working copy.

The proposed workflow uses IXImager as the imaging tool and considers an ASB container as the evidence-storage/container format identified in the case. The exact options and capabilities available depend on the installed software version and laboratory configuration; therefore, investigators should document the actual version, settings and validation status used.

1.1 Investigation Objectives

- Safely identify, collect, transport and secure the laptop and USB device.
- Prevent accidental modification of the original storage media.
- Create a forensic image using a controlled acquisition process.
- Verify the acquired image using cryptographic hash values.
- Document all acquisition and handling activities for defensibility.
- Explain the use of an ASB container for organizing/storing forensic evidence.
- Recover file content through data carving when file-system structures are missing or damaged.
- Account for time-zone, clock and timestamp uncertainties during examination.

1.2 Fundamental Forensic Principle

The original evidence should be preserved as far as reasonably possible. Acquisition creates a forensic representation that can be examined repeatedly without repeatedly interacting with the original device. Integrity checks, chain-of-custody records and documented procedures make it possible to demonstrate what evidence was received, how it was acquired and whether the acquired copy remained unchanged.

1.3 Assumptions

- The investigation team has lawful authority to seize and examine the laptop and USB device.
- The laptop and USB device are treated as separate evidence items.
- An approved write-protection method is available where required.
- Example identifiers, hashes, timestamps and custody entries in this assignment are illustrative and must be replaced by actual case information.

2. Safe Collection and Transportation Procedure

The collection phase begins before the laptop is connected to any forensic workstation. Investigators should document the physical state and power condition of the equipment and prevent unauthorized access during transport.

2.1 Step-by-Step Collection

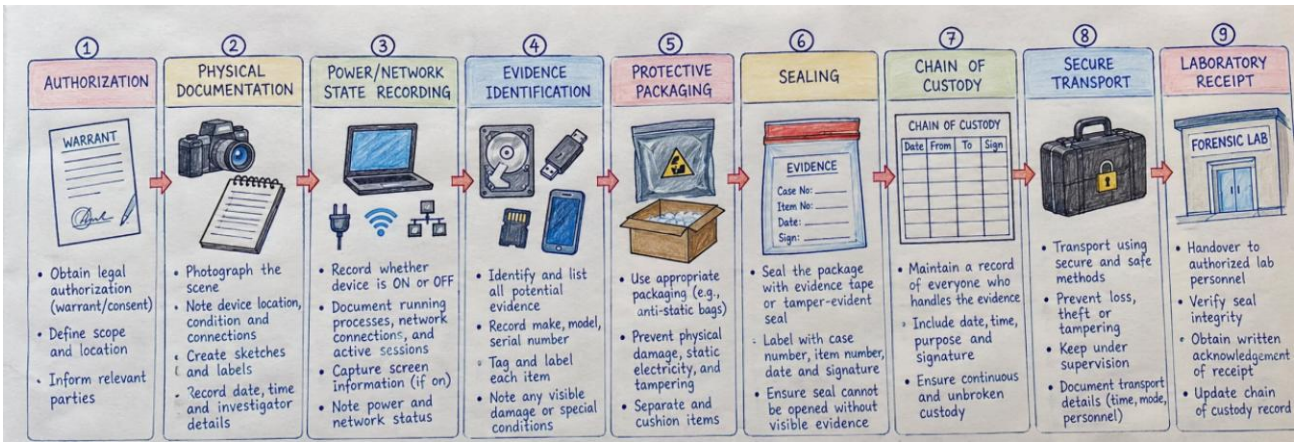
1. Obtain and record the appropriate seizure/search authorization and case reference.
2. Photograph or document the laptop, USB device, cables, ports, labels, serial numbers and visible condition.
3. Record whether the laptop is powered on, powered off, locked, or displaying an active session.

4. Do not browse files or interact with the operating system merely to identify evidence.
5. If the laptop is powered on, follow the approved live-response procedure when volatile evidence is relevant; otherwise, document the decision before shutdown.
6. Disconnect the laptop from wired or wireless networks where the approved procedure requires isolation, taking care not to alter evidence unnecessarily.
7. Remove or separately package the USB device if it can be safely identified and preserved without changing evidence.
8. Assign unique evidence IDs, for example LAP-001 for the laptop and USB-001 for the USB device.
9. Place devices in appropriate anti-static/protective packaging and use tamper-evident seals.
10. Record the collector, date/time, location, device condition and seal number.
11. Transport the evidence securely and maintain custody until it reaches the forensic laboratory.

2.2 Transportation Precautions

- Protect storage devices from physical shock, moisture, static electricity and extreme temperatures.
- Keep evidence under controlled access during transport.
- Do not leave devices unattended in public areas or unsecured vehicles.
- Use separate packaging and identifiers so that the laptop and USB device cannot be confused.
- Record any damaged seal, physical change or unexpected event immediately.

2.3 Collection Flow



3. Physical Acquisition and Forensic Imaging

3.1 Meaning of Physical Acquisition

Physical acquisition aims to capture the contents of a storage device at the storage-media level rather than collecting only selected user files. Depending on the acquisition method, the image can include allocated files, deleted remnants, file-system structures, unallocated space and other areas relevant to forensic analysis.

3.2 Why Analyze the Image Instead of the Original?

- Repeated examination of original media can change system metadata or other evidence.
- A verified forensic image provides a stable working copy that can be examined multiple times.
- Multiple investigators can work from controlled copies without repeatedly handling the original.
- Hashes can be used to demonstrate that the image corresponds to the acquired evidence and has not changed after acquisition.

- An image can preserve information that ordinary file copying would omit, including deleted or unallocated data when acquired appropriately.

3.3 Acquisition Preparation

- Identify the source device by make, model, serial number and capacity.
- Connect the source through an appropriate write blocker or equivalent approved protection mechanism.
- Confirm the destination storage has sufficient capacity and is itself suitable for forensic use.
- Record the imaging tool, version, acquisition format and relevant settings.
- Ensure the source and destination are clearly distinguished to prevent accidental overwrite.

4. Forensic Imaging Workflow Using IXImager

IXImager is used here as the designated forensic imaging application in the case study. The exact interface and available acquisition options depend on the installed release. The workflow below describes the intended procedure and should be adapted to the validated laboratory configuration.

Stage	Procedure
1. Case setup	Create/identify the case and record the case number, examiner, evidence ID and acquisition purpose.
2. Source identification	Select the correct laptop storage device or USB source using device model, serial number and capacity. Confirm the source carefully before acquisition.
3. Write protection	Connect the source through an approved write blocker or equivalent read-only protection. Verify that the source is not mounted for normal write access.
4. Destination preparation	Select a clean forensic destination with adequate free space. Confirm that the destination will not overwrite any evidence.
5. Acquisition format	Select the laboratory-approved image/container format and configure segmentation or compression if applicable.
6. Acquisition start	Start imaging and record start time, source details, destination path/container, examiner and relevant tool settings.
7. Progress monitoring	Monitor for read errors, bad sectors or interruptions. Record any error and the recovery behavior used.
8. Hash calculation	Generate the required cryptographic hash values for the source/acquired data as supported by the workflow.
9. Verification	Use the tool's verification mechanism, where available, to compare calculated values and confirm acquisition integrity.
10. Evidence sealing	Close and secure the image/container. Apply controlled permissions and record its storage location.
11. Documentation	Complete the acquisition log, chain of custody and evidence inventory.
12. Working copy	Create a verified working copy for forensic examination; preserve the master acquisition as evidence.

4.1 IXImager Acquisition Record

Field	Example Entry
Case ID	CDF-2026-003
Evidence ID	LAP-001
Source	Internal NVMe SSD – serial recorded in evidence log
Secondary Source	USB-001
Tool	IXImager – installed/validated version to be recorded
Image/Container	Laboratory-approved forensic format / ASB where applicable
Hash	SHA-256 value generated during acquisition

Field	Example Entry
Start/End	Actual laboratory timestamps
Examiner	Name and signature/identifier
Verification	Pass/Fail with recorded verification result
Storage	Controlled evidence repository location

5. Hash Values and Evidence Integrity

A cryptographic hash is a fixed-length value generated from digital data. If the data changes, the resulting hash is expected to change. In forensic work, hash values are therefore useful for demonstrating that an acquired image or exported evidence item remains unchanged after acquisition.

5.1 Integrity Verification Process

1. Calculate the selected cryptographic hash value during or immediately after acquisition.
2. Record the algorithm and complete hash value in the acquisition log.
3. Store the recorded hash securely with the case documentation.
4. Before examination, calculate or verify the hash of the image/container.
5. Compare the current value with the acquisition value.
6. If the values match, document that the integrity check passed.
7. If the values do not match, stop relying on the affected copy, preserve it, investigate the discrepancy and document the incident.

5.2 Example Integrity Record

Evidence	Algorithm	Acquisition Hash	Verification Result
LAP-001 image	SHA-256	[Actual 64-character hash to be inserted]	PASS after verification
USB-001 image	SHA-256	[Actual 64-character hash to be inserted]	PASS after verification

The values above are placeholders. A report must never invent a hash value. The actual value should be copied directly from the forensic acquisition record.

- Supports demonstration that the working image is identical to the acquired image.
- Helps detect accidental or unauthorized modification.
- Allows independent examiners to verify the integrity of the evidence they received.
- Provides a concise integrity reference in the final forensic report.

6. ASB Container and Evidence Management

In this case study, ASB is considered as the forensic container format specified by the investigation scenario. A forensic container is intended to hold acquired digital evidence together with information needed to manage, verify and examine it. The precise capabilities of the ASB format should be confirmed against the version and documentation available in the laboratory.

6.1 Role of a Forensic Container

- Preserves acquired evidence in a structured representation suitable for forensic examination.
- Can provide a controlled way to store image data and associated acquisition information.
- May support metadata such as evidence identifiers, source information and integrity information depending on the implementation.

- Can simplify transfer and management of an evidence image while keeping the forensic context with the acquisition.
- Should be protected against unauthorized modification and stored in a controlled evidence repository.

6.2 Information Accompanying the Evidence

Information	Purpose
Case number / evidence ID	Uniquely identifies the evidence.
Source device details	Records make, model, serial number, capacity and media type.
Acquisition date/time	Establishes when imaging occurred.
Examiner identity	Identifies the person responsible for acquisition.
Tool and version	Makes the acquisition process reproducible and auditable.
Acquisition settings	Documents format, compression, segmentation and error-handling options.
Hash algorithm and value	Supports integrity verification.
Write-protection details	Shows how source modification was prevented.
Chain-of-custody record	Documents evidence possession and transfers.
Storage location	Shows where the master evidence is secured.

6.3 Safekeeping

The master image/container should be retained as evidence with restricted access. Examination should use a verified working copy. Access to the master should be logged, and any additional copy should be uniquely identified and integrity-checked.

7. Data Carving

Data carving is a recovery technique that attempts to identify and reconstruct files from raw storage data using characteristics such as file signatures, headers, footers and internal structure. It can be useful when normal file-system records are missing, damaged or unavailable.

7.1 When Carving May Be Necessary

- File-system metadata is corrupted or partially destroyed.
- Files have been deleted and their directory entries are unavailable.
- Unallocated space may contain remnants of relevant files.
- A partition or file-system structure is damaged.
- A forensic image contains raw data but the normal directory structure cannot be relied upon.

7.2 Carving Procedure

1. Preserve the original image and work from a verified copy.
2. Identify the relevant storage area or unallocated space.
3. Use a validated carving tool or forensic platform.
4. Search for known file signatures and supported formats.
5. Extract recovered objects into a separate evidence location.
6. Calculate hashes for recovered files and retain their source offsets/locations.
7. Validate recovered content where possible and distinguish complete files from fragments.
8. Document the carving method, tool/version, signatures used and limitations.

7.3 Limitations of Carving

- Fragmented files may be recovered incompletely or incorrectly.
- Recovered data may not preserve original file names, paths or ownership information.
- False positives can occur when byte patterns resemble known file signatures.

8. Date/Time Problems in Digital Evidence

Time is central to forensic reconstruction, but timestamps from different systems are not automatically comparable. Investigators should identify the time source, time zone, daylight-saving behavior where applicable, system clock accuracy and timestamp semantics.

8.1 Common Time Problems

- Computer clock may be fast or slow.
- Different systems may use different time zones.
- UTC and local time may be displayed differently.
- Daylight-saving changes can affect local-time interpretation.
- File creation, modification and access times may have different meanings.
- Copying, extraction, synchronization or restoration can alter timestamps.
- Logs from network devices and servers may use independent clocks.

8.2 Recommended Documentation

Time Item	What to Record
System clock	Observed system date/time and reference time.
Time zone	Configured zone and UTC offset.
Synchronization	NTP or other clock-synchronization status if available.
Timestamp source	File system, event log, application, browser, USB or other source.
Conversion	Original timestamp and normalized reporting time.



Fig 1. Seized Laptop and USB Device (Before Imaging)

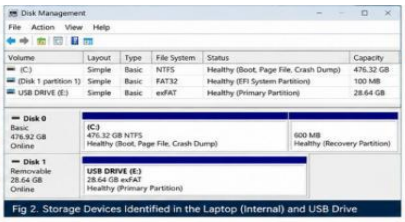


Fig 2. Storage Devices Identified in the Laptop (Internal) and USB Drive



Fig 3. IXImager – Source Device Selection



Fig 4. Forensic Imaging in Progress Using IXImager

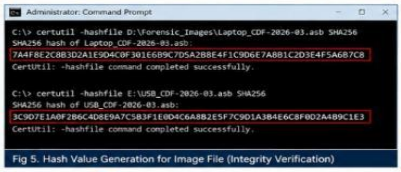


Fig 5. Hash Value Generation for Image File (Integrity Verification)

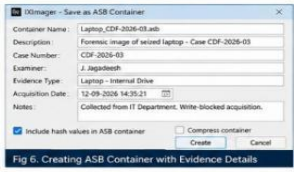


Fig 6. Creating ASB Container with Evidence Details

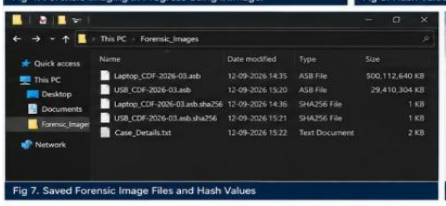


Fig 7. Saved Forensic Image Files and Hash Values



Fig 8. Analysis of Forensic Image (File Carving / Recovered Files)

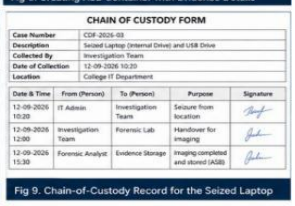


Fig 9. Chain-of-Custody Record for the Seized Laptop

9. Chain of Custody – Seized Laptop

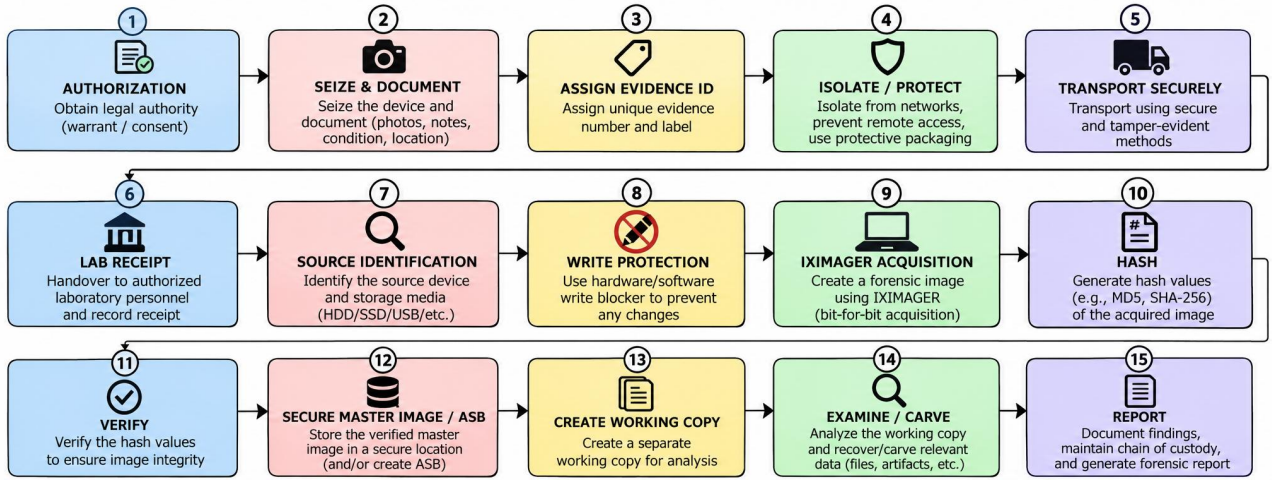
Chain of custody documents the movement and handling of evidence from collection through laboratory examination and secure storage. Every transfer should identify who released the evidence, who received it, when it occurred, why it occurred and whether the evidence seal/condition changed.

Date/Time	Evidence ID	Released By	Received By	Purpose / Location	Seal / Condition
07/10/2026	LAP-001	Field Investigator	Evidence Custodian	Initial submission to evidence room	Seal intact
07/10/2026	LAP-001	Evidence Custodian	Forensic Examiner	Transfer to forensic laboratory	Seal intact
07/10/2026	LAP-001	Forensic Examiner	Forensic Lab Storage	Return after imaging	New/verified seal recorded
07/10/2026	USB-001	Field Investigator	Evidence Custodian	Initial submission	Seal intact
07/10/2026	USB-001	Evidence Custodian	Forensic Examiner	Imaging/examination	Seal intact
07/10/2026	USB-001	Forensic Examiner	Forensic Lab Storage	Return to secure storage	Condition recorded

9.1 Minimum Chain-of-Custody Information

- Case number and evidence identifier.
- Detailed description and serial number where available.
- Date/time of each custody event.
- Name/identifier and signature of releasing person.
- Name/identifier and signature of receiving person.
- Purpose of transfer and destination.
- Seal number and condition.
- Any discrepancy, damage or unusual event.

10. Integrated Acquisition Flowchart



11. Forensic Report Structure

Section	Content
Case information	Case number, examiner, dates and investigation scope.
Evidence inventory	Laptop, USB device, storage media and evidence IDs.
Collection procedure	Seizure, packaging, transport and custody details.
Acquisition methodology	IXImager version, write protection, image format and settings.
Integrity verification	Hash algorithms, values and verification results.
ASB/container information	Container details and evidence-management information where used.
Carving methodology	Tool, target area, signatures and recovered objects where applicable.
Timeline/time analysis	Time zone, clock and timestamp assumptions/uncertainties.

Section	Content
Findings	Objective observations linked to evidence IDs.
Limitations	Missing data, damaged sectors, time uncertainty and other constraints.
Conclusion	Supported conclusions stated without overstating certainty.
Appendices	Chain of custody, hash list, screenshots, logs and acquisition records.

12. Conclusion

Forensic imaging is the foundation of a defensible examination because it allows investigators to preserve the original storage device and conduct analysis on a controlled copy. In this case, the laptop and USB device should be carefully documented, protected, transported and acquired using an approved workflow. IXImager can be used to identify the source, apply write protection, acquire the storage media, calculate and verify hashes, and document the resulting image. The ASB container specified in the case can be treated as a structured evidence container subject to the capabilities and validation requirements of the installed implementation. Data carving provides an additional recovery technique when file-system information is damaged or unavailable, but carved files must be correlated with other evidence.

Finally, integrity verification, accurate time documentation and chain-of-custody records are essential. A technically successful image is not sufficient by itself; the investigation must also demonstrate how the evidence was collected, preserved, verified, examined and stored.

4. Recovery of Deleted Evidence from Volume Shadow Copies

1. Case Study Overview

This case study examines the recovery and interpretation of deleted or changed evidence from a Windows forensic image containing Volume Shadow Copies (VSS). An employee is suspected of deleting documents and browser-related artifacts after an unauthorized activity. Investigators must determine what evidence is relevant, identify artifacts that may have been deleted or modified, examine earlier versions preserved by shadow copies, and reconstruct a defensible sequence of events.

Volume Shadow Copies can preserve earlier states of files or system information. They can therefore provide valuable historical evidence when the current file system no longer contains an artifact. However, the existence of an earlier copy does not automatically establish who created, accessed or deleted the file. Findings must be correlated with independent evidence and validated before being reported.

1.1 Investigation Objectives

- Identify and categorize relevant evidence before detailed examination.
- Separate user-created, system/application, suspicious, deleted/recovered and contextual artifacts.
- Use Event Analysis to reconstruct a sequence of activities.
- Explain the roles of Cloud Analysis and Lead Analysis in extending investigative hypotheses.
- Use Volume Shadow Copy analysis to compare earlier and current states.
- Construct a timeline covering creation, modification, copying, deletion and recovery.
- Validate recovered artifacts for integrity, provenance and relevance.
- Document timestamp uncertainties and alternative explanations.

1.2 Scope and Assumptions

- The available forensic image is a verified working copy of the seized Windows system.
- Volume Shadow Copies are present and accessible for forensic examination.
- The investigation is authorized and limited to relevant evidence.
- Example file names and times used in the timeline are hypothetical and are not actual findings.
- Any tool workflow should be adapted to the specific forensic platform/version used in the laboratory.

1.3 Core Principle

A recovered artifact is evidence only after its source, integrity, timing and relevance have been established. Investigators should distinguish between what an artifact directly demonstrates and what it merely suggests when combined with other evidence.

2. Evidence Selection and Categorization

Before detailed analysis, investigators should define the investigation question and filter the evidence accordingly. The goal is not to examine every file equally, but to preserve and prioritize artifacts that can answer the relevant investigative questions.

2.1 Evidence Selection Procedure

1. Define the incident period and the suspected user/activity.
2. Identify storage volumes, user profiles and application areas relevant to the incident.
3. Preserve the original forensic image and work from a verified copy.
4. Generate an initial inventory of files, directories, logs and shadow-copy sources.

5. Tag artifacts that are potentially relevant to the allegation.
6. Separate irrelevant or clearly unrelated material from the active analytical set while retaining its existence in the evidence inventory.
7. Prioritize artifacts that can establish identity, timing, action, source and destination.
8. Record why an artifact was included or excluded from detailed analysis.

2.2 Evidence Classification Scheme

Category	Typical Examples	Investigative Purpose	Priority
User-created files	Documents, spreadsheets, PDFs, images, scripts	May establish content, authorship context or user activity	High
System/Application files	Windows logs, registry artifacts, browser databases, application caches	Provide technical context and activity records	High
Potentially suspicious files	Unknown executables, unusual scripts, unauthorized archives	May identify the method or source of unauthorized activity	Very High
Deleted/Recovered artifacts	Deleted documents, recovered browser databases, VSS versions	May reveal earlier evidence no longer present in current file system	Very High
Supporting/Contextual evidence	Login records, network information, configuration files, timestamps	Corroborates or challenges primary evidence	Medium/High
Irrelevant/Out-of-scope data	Unrelated personal files or routine system content	Normally excluded from detailed analysis to maintain scope	Low

2.3 Relevance Criteria

- Does the artifact fall within the incident time window?
- Does it relate to the suspected user, file, application or activity?
- Does it help establish what happened, when, how or by whom?
- Does it corroborate or contradict another artifact?
- Is it technically reliable and traceable to a known source?

3. Event Analysis and Activity Reconstruction

Event Analysis combines timestamped records from multiple sources to reconstruct the sequence of activities. The objective is to move from isolated artifacts to a chronological explanation that can be tested against independent evidence.

3.1 Useful Event Sources

Source	Potential Events
Windows event logs	Logon/logoff, process or service events, security events and system activity.
File-system metadata	Creation, modification, access and deletion-related information.
Browser artifacts	Downloads, browsing history, cache, cookies and application activity.
Registry artifacts	User/application configuration and activity-related records.
Recycle Bin	Deleted file information and original paths where available.
Volume Shadow Copies	Earlier versions of files and file-system state.
Application logs	Document access, archive tools, synchronization or other application actions.
Network artifacts	Connections, shares or transfers where relevant and lawfully available.

3.2 Event Analysis Procedure

1. Extract timestamped events from each relevant evidence source.
2. Record the original timestamp and source for every event.
3. Determine the time zone and system-clock assumptions.
4. Normalize timestamps into a common reporting format while preserving original values.
5. Sort events chronologically.
6. Group events that appear to belong to the same user session or activity.
7. Compare independent sources for corroboration.
8. Mark contradictions, missing events and uncertain timestamps.
9. Form and test hypotheses rather than assuming that chronological proximity proves causation.

3.3 Example Event Correlation

A browser download at 20:10, a file creation event at 20:11, a process-execution artifact at 20:13 and a subsequent deletion event at 20:20 could form a meaningful sequence. However, the investigator must still establish whether these events belong to the same user/session and whether another process could have produced them.

4. Cloud Analysis and Lead Analysis

4.1 Cloud Analysis

Cloud Analysis examines evidence associated with cloud-based services, synchronization applications and online accounts when such data is lawfully available within the investigation scope. Cloud artifacts can help determine whether a file was uploaded, downloaded, synchronized or accessed through an online service.

Question	Possible Evidence
Was a document synchronized to cloud storage?	Sync logs, cloud client database, local sync folder metadata.
When did synchronization occur?	Application logs and cloud-service timestamps.
Which account/profile was used?	Account identifiers, application profile artifacts and authentication records.
Was a local file downloaded from the cloud?	Browser/download artifacts, sync records and file metadata.
Does a cloud copy explain the presence or absence of a local file?	Version/synchronization history and local application artifacts.

4.2 Lead Analysis

Lead Analysis is an investigative process for developing, testing and documenting follow-up questions based on evidence already discovered. A lead is not a conclusion. It is a direction for additional examination.

- A suspicious filename may lead investigators to search other volumes or shadow copies.
- A deleted browser database may lead to examination of browser cache, download records or synchronized profiles.
- A timestamp conflict may lead to examination of system clock settings or time synchronization.
- A recovered document may lead to searches for copies, archives or transfer artifacts.
- A username in an application record may lead to examination of corresponding login/session evidence.

4.3 Lead Analysis Discipline

- Record the source that generated the lead.
- State the question being tested.
- Identify the evidence needed to confirm or reject the lead.
- Record both confirming and contradictory results.
- Do not convert an untested lead into a final finding.

5. Volume Shadow Copy Analysis

Volume Shadow Copy Service (VSS) is a Windows mechanism that can preserve point-in-time copies or snapshots used by system and application processes. From a forensic perspective, available shadow copies may provide historical versions of files and directories that differ from the current state.

5.1 Forensic Value of VSS

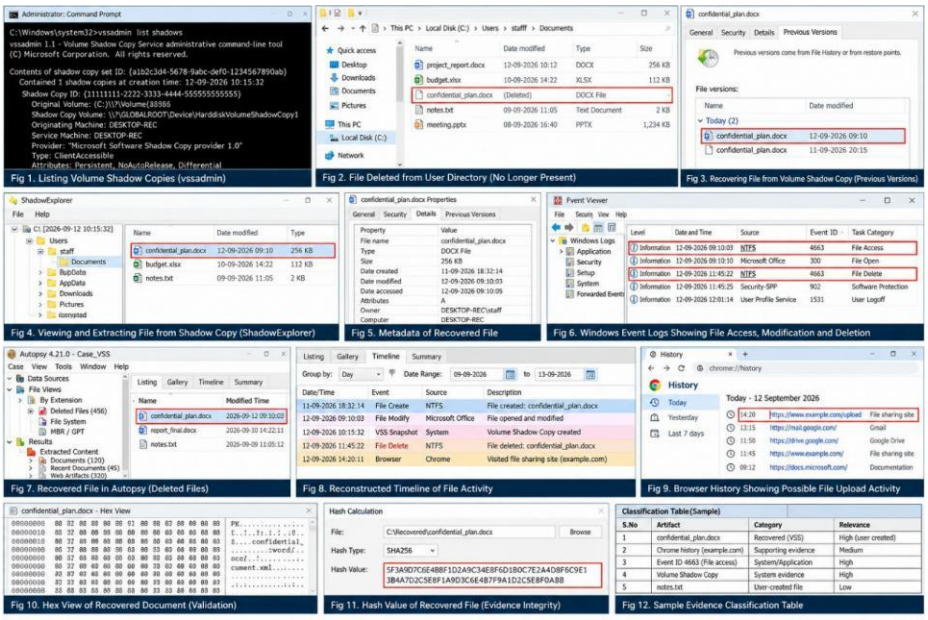
- A deleted or modified file may still exist in an earlier snapshot.
- An earlier version can be compared with the current file to identify changes.
- Historical directory structures can show that an artifact existed at an earlier point.
- Previous browser or application databases may preserve records that are no longer present in the live system.
- Shadow-copy evidence can help narrow the time window in which an artifact changed.

5.2 VSS Recovery Workflow

1. Verify the forensic image and identify available VSS snapshots.
2. Record the snapshot identifiers, creation times and associated volumes.
3. Mount or access the relevant snapshot using an approved forensic method.
4. Navigate to the relevant user/application path.
5. Search for the suspected file, deleted artifact or earlier version.
6. Export the recovered artifact to a controlled evidence directory.
7. Record the snapshot source, path, timestamp and extraction method.
8. Calculate a hash for the recovered artifact.
9. Compare the recovered version with the current version where applicable.
10. Correlate the recovery with event logs, file metadata and other artifacts.
11. Document findings, limitations and the exact source of the recovered artifact.

5.3 VSS Comparison

Current State	Shadow Copy State	Potential Interpretation
File absent	File exists in earlier snapshot	Supports that the file existed previously; deletion timing requires further evidence.
File modified	Earlier version differs	Can show historical content/state and possible change window.
Browser database missing	Earlier database present	May preserve historical browser activity.
Directory changed	Earlier directory contains artifact	Supports historical existence of the artifact.



6. Hypothetical Event Timeline

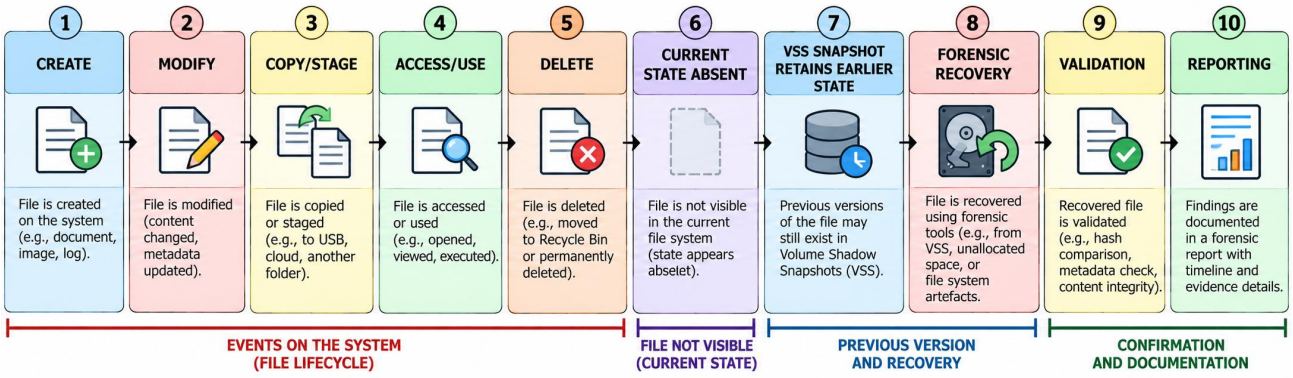
The following timeline is an illustrative reconstruction showing how an artifact might be created, modified, copied, deleted and later recovered from a Volume Shadow Copy. These times are hypothetical and must not be presented as actual case findings.

Date/Time	Evidence Source	Event	Interpretation
10 Oct 2026 18:05	Windows session log	User session begins	Potential start of relevant activity.
18:12	File system	Report.docx created in user Documents	Initial creation of the document.
18:18	File metadata	Report.docx modified	Document content changed.
18:24	Browser/download	Related archive downloaded	Possible source or supporting activity.
18:27	File system	Copy of Report.docx created in another directory	Possible staging/backup/transfer preparation.
18:34	Browser artifact	Browser-related artifact accessed	Possible interaction with relevant online activity.
18:41	File system	Original Report.docx deleted	Current file-system state no longer contains the original.
18:50	Recycle Bin / deletion artifact	Deleted-file metadata observed	May help establish original path and deletion context.
11 Oct 2026 09:10	VSS snapshot	Earlier snapshot contains Report.docx	Historical copy demonstrates prior existence.
11 Oct 2026 09:25	Forensic extraction	Report.docx recovered from VSS	Recovered artifact preserved for validation.

6.1 Timeline Interpretation

The timeline can support the hypothesis that a document existed before deletion and remained recoverable in a shadow copy. It does not, by itself, prove why the document was deleted or who performed the deletion. User attribution requires corroboration from account/session artifacts and other independent evidence.

6.2 Timeline Diagram



7. Validation of Recovered Artifacts

A recovered artifact should not be included as a final finding merely because a forensic tool successfully extracted it. The investigator should establish provenance, integrity, relevance and consistency with other evidence.

7.1 Validation Checklist

Validation Check	Question to Answer
Source verified	Which VSS snapshot and volume produced the artifact?
Path recorded	What was the original path in the snapshot?
Snapshot time recorded	When was the snapshot created?
Extraction documented	Which tool/method produced the recovered file?
Hash calculated	What is the SHA-256 hash of the recovered artifact?
Integrity verified	Was the extracted artifact preserved unchanged after acquisition?
Content validated	Does the recovered content open correctly and appear internally consistent?
Cross-source corroboration	Do logs or other artifacts support the same event?
Timestamp assessed	Have time-zone and clock issues been considered?
Alternative explanations	Could another process explain the artifact?
Relevance established	Does the artifact answer an investigation question?
Reporting reference	Is the evidence ID/source path recorded in the report?

7.2 Comparing Recovered and Current Artifacts

- Compare file hashes when the recovered and current versions are expected to be identical.
- Compare file sizes and metadata.
- Use content comparison to identify additions, deletions or modifications where appropriate.
- Record whether the recovered artifact is complete or partially reconstructed.
- Preserve both versions with separate evidence identifiers.

7.3 Validation Outcome

A recovered artifact should be described as validated only when the examiner can identify its source, preserve its integrity, explain its relevance and reasonably corroborate its interpretation. If any of these elements is uncertain, the report should state the limitation rather than overstating the finding.

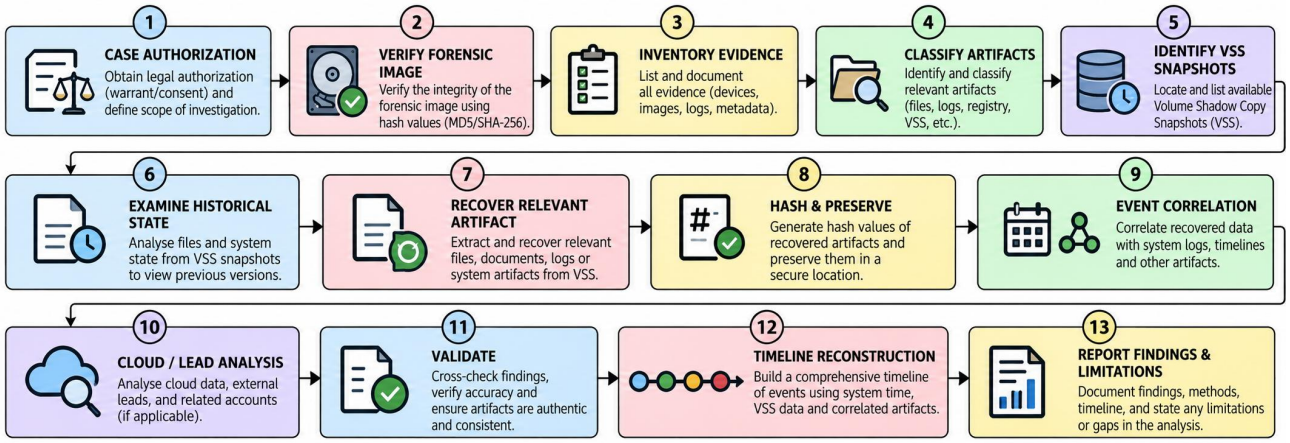
8. Sources of Error and Alternative Explanations

Issue	Potential Effect	Recommended Response
System clock drift	Events may appear earlier/later than they actually occurred	Compare with trusted time sources and document observed offsets.
Time-zone differences	Events from different sources may appear inconsistent	Record original time zone and normalize carefully.
File-copy behavior	Creation/access times may change during copying	Determine the source and operation that produced the timestamp.
VSS creation time	Snapshot time does not equal the time of the original user action	Treat VSS timestamp as the snapshot state, not automatically the event time.
Deleted-file remnants	Recovered content may be incomplete	Check file structure, size and recovery status.
Application caching	Artifacts may reflect automated background activity	Correlate with user sessions and application logs.
Cloud synchronization	Files may appear without direct user action at that moment	Examine sync logs and account context.
Shared accounts	Account activity may not identify the physical user	Seek independent attribution evidence.
Automated deletion	Scheduled tools may delete files	Examine task/service and application records.
Anti-forensic activity	Timestamps or files may have been intentionally altered	Look for inconsistencies and corroborate independently.

8.1 Reporting Uncertainty

The final report should distinguish observed facts from interpretations. For example, the report may state that a document was present in a VSS snapshot created at a particular time and absent from the current file system. It should not automatically state that the employee deleted it at that time unless additional evidence establishes the deletion event and attribution.

9. Integrated Volume Shadow Copy Investigation Workflow



10. Sample Forensic Report Structure

Section	Content
Executive Summary	Short description of allegation, evidence and major findings.
Scope and Authority	Systems, accounts, time period and authorization.
Evidence Inventory	Forensic image, VSS snapshots and extracted artifacts.
Methodology	Classification, Event Analysis, VSS recovery, validation and timeline procedures.
Evidence Classification	Categories and rationale for prioritization.
VSS Examination	Snapshot identifiers, times, paths and recovered artifacts.
Event Timeline	Chronological reconstruction with evidence references.
Cloud/Lead Analysis	Relevant investigative questions and corroborating results.
Validation	Hashes, provenance, source and cross-source verification.
Limitations	Timestamp issues, missing logs, incomplete recovery and alternatives.
Conclusion	Supported conclusions stated with appropriate confidence.
Appendices	Screenshots, hash list, extraction records, evidence tables and chain-of-custody documents.

11. Conclusion

Volume Shadow Copies can provide an important historical view of a Windows system when current files have been deleted or modified. A disciplined forensic process begins by selecting and categorizing relevant evidence, followed by Event Analysis and targeted examination of historical snapshots. Cloud Analysis and Lead Analysis can extend the investigation by identifying synchronization evidence and generating testable follow-up questions.

A recovered artifact from a VSS snapshot is valuable because it can demonstrate that a file or application artifact existed at an earlier point in time. However, recovery alone does not establish user intent or attribution. The artifact must be validated through source identification, hashing, timestamp assessment and corroboration with independent evidence.

The strongest forensic conclusion is therefore one that combines historical VSS evidence with current file-system records, system/application events and user/session artifacts while clearly documenting uncertainty. This approach produces a defensible reconstruction without overstating what the evidence can prove.

5. Multi-Source Investigation of a Suspected Cyber Incident

1. Case Study Overview

This case study concerns a suspected cyber incident in which a student account may have been used to gain unauthorized access to an online service. Unlike an investigation limited to a single computer, the available evidence is distributed across a Windows computer, browser artifacts, email and messaging records, a mobile phone, and Internet or cloud services.

The main forensic challenge is to correlate evidence from different technologies and determine whether the artifacts describe the same sequence of events. Investigators must preserve each source, document acquisition and access methods, normalize time information, and distinguish direct evidence from corroborating evidence and unresolved questions.

1.1 Investigation Objectives

- Identify relevant evidence from Windows and other operating systems.
- Explain the evidentiary value and limitations of browser artifacts.
- Examine email and messaging evidence and correlate it with device activity.
- Describe mobile-phone forensic considerations and acquisition challenges.
- Identify relevant Internet and cloud evidence sources.
- Correlate artifacts across at least five independent sources.
- Analyze the major challenges created by distributed digital evidence.
- Prepare a balanced final conclusion separating direct evidence, corroboration and unresolved issues.

1.2 Scope and Assumptions

- Investigators have appropriate legal or organizational authorization for each evidence source.
- The Windows computer, mobile phone and online records are treated as separate evidence sources.
- Examples in this report are hypothetical and are not actual forensic findings.
- Cloud, email and messaging data are examined only to the extent lawfully available.
- Time zones and device clocks must be documented before cross-source correlation.

1.3 Core Forensic Principle

Correlation increases confidence but does not automatically prove causation. An artifact should be interpreted according to what it directly demonstrates, what it supports when combined with other evidence, and what remains uncertain.

2. Windows and Other Operating-System Evidence

Operating systems generate many artifacts that can help establish user sessions, file activity, application use and system changes. The relevant sources depend on the device and operating system involved.

Operating System / Source	Potential Evidence	Investigative Value
Windows	Security/Event logs, registry, user profiles, NTFS metadata	User sessions, system activity, file and application context.
Windows browser profiles	History, downloads, cache, cookies, saved sessions	Possible web activity and acquisition of files.
Windows application artifacts	Recent files, application logs, shortcuts and jump-list style records	Evidence of application interaction with files.

Operating System / Source	Potential Evidence	Investigative Value
Linux	Authentication logs, shell history, file metadata, process/service logs	Login, command and system activity.
macOS	Unified logs, user directories, application artifacts, file metadata	User/session and application activity.
Android	App data, notifications, account data, device metadata	Mobile application and communication context.
iOS	Application databases, system logs and device/account artifacts where accessible	Communication, application and account context.

2.1 Windows Evidence Priorities

- Identify the relevant user account and session periods.
- Examine authentication records around the suspected incident.
- Review file-system artifacts related to downloads, scripts, tools or documents.
- Correlate browser activity with local file creation or access.
- Preserve registry, logs and application artifacts before interpretation.

2.2 Cross-Operating-System Caution

Different operating systems record events using different formats, timestamp conventions and retention policies. A missing artifact on one platform does not necessarily mean that an event did not occur. Investigators should record both the presence and absence of relevant evidence.

3. Browser Artifacts and User Activity

Web browsers can preserve evidence about websites visited, searches, downloads, cookies, cached resources, sessions and browser profiles. These artifacts can help reconstruct online activity, but they must be interpreted carefully because automated processes and synchronization can generate browser-related records.

Browser Artifact	Possible Information	Interpretation Caution
History	URLs, visit times, page titles	A visit may be automated, preloaded or caused by an application.
Downloads	File name, source URL, download time and path	Strong contextual evidence but account/session correlation is required.
Cache	Previously accessed web resources	Does not always prove that the user intentionally viewed the content.
Cookies	Site/session identifiers	Can indicate browser interaction but may be copied or synchronized.
Saved sessions	Authenticated site state	Requires careful attribution to the person using the device.
Search history	Queries and timestamps	Useful context; does not necessarily prove intent or action.
Browser profile	Account/profile association	May link artifacts to a profile but not automatically to the physical person.

3.1 Browser Correlation

- Compare browser download time with file-system creation time.
- Compare browser activity with the authenticated Windows user session.
- Check whether the browser profile belongs to the suspected account.
- Correlate URLs with email or messaging links where relevant.
- Check for synchronization or shared-browser scenarios before attributing activity.

3.2 Why Browser Evidence Must Be Interpreted Carefully

Browser artifacts can be incomplete, deleted, synchronized or generated automatically. A webpage may load because of background processes, extensions or prefetching. Therefore, a browser record should normally be treated as part of a larger evidentiary pattern rather than as standalone proof of user intent.

4. Email and Messaging Evidence

Email and messaging systems can provide both content and metadata. The evidentiary value depends on the source, authenticity, retention and acquisition method.

Evidence Type	Examples	Possible Correlation
Email headers	Sender, recipient, message ID, dates, routing information	Can correlate communication with account/device/network activity.
Email content	Messages, attachments, links and instructions	May explain motivation, communication or file transfer.
Attachments	Documents, archives, images or executable files	Can be compared with files found on the computer.
Messaging records	Chats, timestamps, participant identifiers	Can establish communications around the incident.
Message attachments	Shared files or images	Can be hashed and compared with local/cloud artifacts.
Account logs	Login/security notifications	Can correlate account access with device activity.
Deleted/recovered messages	Recovered mailbox or app records where available	May establish earlier communication, subject to recovery reliability.

4.1 Correlation Examples

- An email attachment hash may match a document found on the Windows computer.
- A message timestamp may fall within the same authenticated session as a suspicious browser download.
- A cloud account login notification may correspond with a mobile-device session.
- A link in a message may match a browser history entry shortly afterward.
- An attachment stored on the phone may match an attachment found in cloud storage.

4.2 Email/Messaging Limitations

Message timestamps can be affected by time zones, server processing and device clock differences. Sender information may be spoofed in some contexts, while displayed names do not necessarily establish account ownership. Investigators should preserve original headers or platform metadata where available.

5. Mobile-Phone Forensic Considerations

Mobile devices combine communications, applications, location-related information, photographs, authentication tokens and cloud synchronization. They can therefore provide important corroborating evidence, but acquisition can be technically and legally complex.

5.1 Evidence Sources on a Mobile Phone

- Call logs and contacts.
- SMS and messaging application records.
- Email and cloud-service applications.
- Browser history and downloads.
- Photographs, videos and associated metadata.

- Application databases and notifications.
- Device/account identifiers and authentication records where lawfully available.
- File-system metadata and removable-storage artifacts where applicable.

5.2 Mobile Acquisition Considerations

1. Document device make, model, operating system and physical condition.
2. Record power state, lock state and network connectivity.
3. Prevent remote wiping or unwanted synchronization using an approved isolation procedure where appropriate.
4. Use a validated acquisition method suitable for the device and legal scope.
5. Preserve the original device and work from extracted forensic data.
6. Document extraction method, tool/version, limitations and supported data types.
7. Protect sensitive personal information that is outside the investigation scope.

5.3 Mobile Evidence Challenges

- Encryption and locked devices can restrict access.
- Application updates can change database structures.
- Cloud synchronization may mean local data is incomplete.
- Some applications use end-to-end encryption.
- Deleted content may be unrecoverable or partially recovered.

6. Internet and Cloud-Based Evidence

Internet and cloud services can provide records that exist outside the seized devices. Depending on authorization and provider retention, these sources may help establish account access, file synchronization, remote logins or communication.

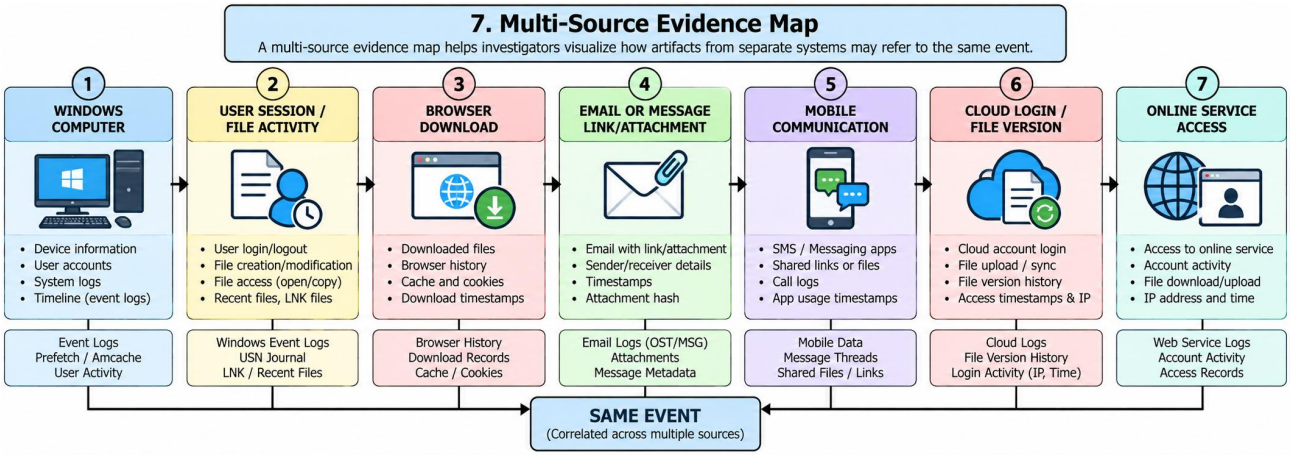
Source	Potential Evidence	Example Question
Cloud storage	File versions, sync activity, sharing records	Was the suspicious file uploaded or shared?
Cloud account security logs	Login times, device/session information	Was the account accessed during the incident window?
Email provider	Server-side messages, headers, account events	Was the communication sent/received and from which account?
Messaging service	Messages, attachments, account/device records where available	Was information exchanged with another participant?
Web service logs	Authentication and access records	When was the online service accessed?
DNS/network records	Domain queries or connection context where available	Did a device resolve/connect to a relevant service?
VPN/proxy records	Connection times and assigned addresses where available	Could traffic have originated through an intermediary?

6.1 Cloud Evidence Handling

- Obtain records through authorized legal or organizational channels.
- Record provider, account identifier and acquisition date.
- Preserve original provider exports where possible.
- Record the provider's timestamp format and time zone.
- Hash downloaded evidence exports when appropriate.
- Do not assume that cloud timestamps use the same clock or time zone as the local device.

7. Multi-Source Evidence Map

A multi-source evidence map helps investigators visualize how artifacts from separate systems may refer to the same event.



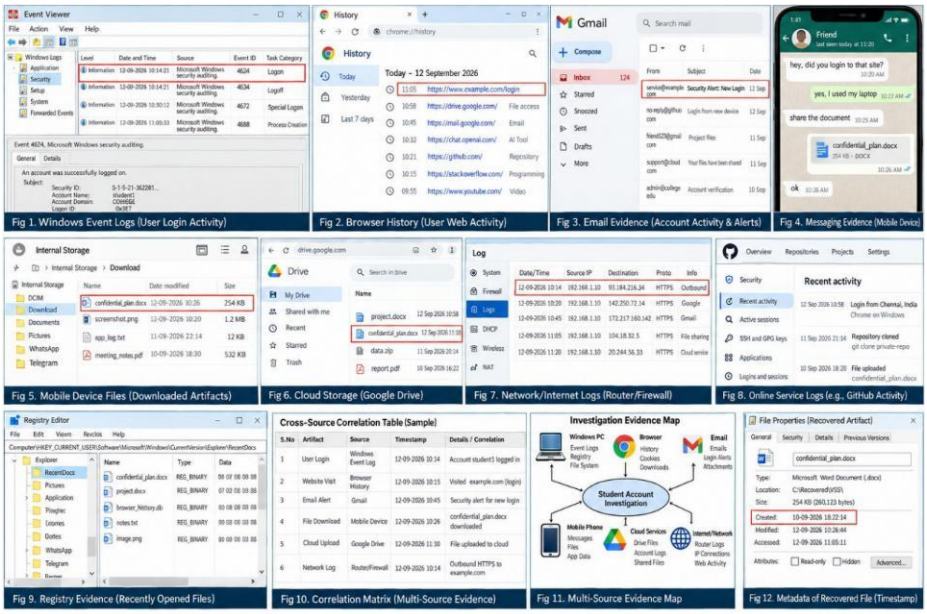
7.1 Evidence Mapping Table

Source	Artifact	Question Answered	Possible Link
Windows	Authenticated user session	Which account was active?	Compare with browser and file timestamps.
Browser	Download/history entry	What online activity occurred?	Compare with file creation and message links.
Email	Attachment/message	Was information communicated or transferred?	Compare hash, timestamps and recipients.
Messaging	Chat/attachment	Was the activity discussed or shared?	Compare with mobile and cloud records.
Mobile	Application/account artifact	Was the same account active on a phone?	Compare account/session timing.
Cloud	Login/file version	Was information synchronized or accessed remotely?	Compare with local file state.
Online service	Access/authentication record	Was the target service accessed?	Compare account and network/device context.

7.2 Cross-Source Correlation Matrix

Artifact	Windows	Browser	Email/Msg	Mobile	Cloud	Strength
User session at 20:00	Primary	Supports	Supports	Supports	Supports	High if independently verified
File downloaded at 20:05	Primary	Primary	Possible source	Possible receipt	Possible sync	High with matching hashes/times
Email attachment hash matches local file	Supports	—	Primary	Possible	Possible	High
Message link followed at 20:12	Supports	Primary	Primary	Primary if sent/received	Possible	High when timestamps align
Cloud login at 20:15	Supports	Supports	—	Primary	Primary	Medium/High
Target service access at 20:18	Supports	Supports	—	Supports	Primary/Server	High if account/device correlation is reliable

The matrix is hypothetical. 'High' indicates potential evidentiary strength after independent validation, not a predetermined conclusion.



8. Major Challenges in Multi-Source Digital Forensics

Challenge	Impact / Mitigation
1. Different timestamp systems	Devices and services may use different time zones, clocks and timestamp semantics. Investigators must normalize times while retaining original values.
2. Encryption and access controls	Device encryption, application encryption and cloud authentication may prevent direct access to evidence.
3. Cloud dependency	Important evidence may reside with third-party providers and may be subject to retention, jurisdiction and authorization limits.
4. Evidence synchronization	The same account may synchronize data across multiple devices, making it difficult to determine which device performed an action.
5. Shared accounts and devices	A username or device identifier may not prove which individual physically performed an action.
6. Data volatility	Logs, sessions, notifications and cloud records may change or expire quickly.
7. Different artifact formats	Windows, mobile, browser, email and cloud systems store evidence differently and require different examination methods.
8. Deleted or incomplete data	Artifacts may be deleted, overwritten, partially recovered or unavailable due to provider retention limits.
9. Privacy and legal scope	Multi-device investigations can expose unrelated personal information and require careful minimization.
10. Attribution versus association	A matching IP, account or timestamp may associate an event with a device or account without proving the identity of the person.
11. Anti-forensic manipulation	Attackers may delete logs, modify timestamps, use privacy tools or route activity through intermediary services.
12. Tool limitations	No single forensic tool necessarily parses every application or cloud source completely; validation may require independent methods.

8.1 Good Practice for Multi-Source Investigations

- Maintain a source-by-source evidence inventory.
- Use common evidence identifiers across reports and exports.

- Normalize time only after recording original timestamp and time zone.
- Correlate independent artifacts before making attribution claims.
- Record missing evidence and tool limitations explicitly.
- Separate direct evidence from supporting evidence and investigative leads.
- Protect irrelevant personal data and follow the authorized scope.

9. Final Investigative Summary

The investigation should begin by preserving each authorized evidence source and documenting the collection or acquisition method. Windows artifacts can establish user sessions and local activity; browser artifacts can provide online activity and download context; email and messaging records can establish communication and file transfer; mobile evidence can provide another view of account and application activity; and cloud or Internet records can provide server-side corroboration.

9.1 Direct Evidence

- A validated server or cloud record directly showing an authenticated account accessed the target service at a specified time.
- A verified local execution or access artifact tied to a specific authenticated session.
- A provider record or message with preserved metadata demonstrating a communication or transfer.

9.2 Corroborating Evidence

- Browser history matching a file download and local file creation.
- An email or message attachment whose hash matches a local or cloud copy.
- Mobile application activity occurring within the same validated time window.
- Cloud synchronization records matching local file changes.

9.3 Unresolved Questions

- Was the physical student the person operating the device at the relevant time?
- Could another person have used the account or device?
- Could synchronization or automated processes have generated some artifacts?
- Are any provider-side records incomplete or unavailable?
- Are timestamp differences fully explained by clock and time-zone analysis?

9.4 Model Final Conclusion

Based on the available evidence, investigators should conclude only what the cross-source correlation supports. If independent computer, browser, communication, mobile and cloud artifacts align in a consistent time window and refer to the same account or activity, the evidence may establish a strong association between the account/device and the incident. However, attribution to a specific individual should remain qualified unless the evidence independently addresses shared credentials, remote access, synchronization and other reasonable alternatives.

The final report should clearly separate direct evidence from corroborating evidence and unresolved questions. This prevents overstatement and makes the investigation more defensible to technical and non-technical reviewers.